

The first step

Priya Raje, 26, a consultant with an HR firm in Mumbai, discovered the potential of the Internet when she wanted to surprise her husband, Ravi, with an exotic holiday package for their second marriage anniversary. However, there was a slight problem. "I was distraught when my travel agent told me that my savings were barely enough to cover the travelling expenses for a week's holiday in Tioman Island, Malaysia, leaving nothing for boarding and other expenses. It really was a huge disappointment."

Actually, it turned out to be a blessing in disguise; a friend advised her to check out several Indian Web sites that give information on holiday destinations within the country. And she chanced upon, what was to be a 'perfect romantic getaway' for her in Lahul and Spiti Valley—places cradled in the breathtaking beauty and serenity of the stately Himalayas.

What's more, she could splurge like a queen and still be within her budget—it was a dream come true.

For exotic getaways within India, the first Web site that you should check out is that of the Ministry of Tourism (www.tourismofindia.com or www.incredibleindia.org). An

interesting feature of this well-designed Web site is the list of useful phrases in Hindi, Kannada, Bengali, Punjabi, Malayalam, Telugu and their English equivalents that come in handy when you visit these states.

Another Web site worth exploring is Outlook Traveller (www.outlooktraveller.com). It's loaded with reams of information. It has holiday ideas and detailed information on several destinations. The travel news and articles segment is a good feature; these news stories and articles talk about the different experiences you can expect when travelling by road, train or air.

All India Travel (www.all-indiatravel.com) is a Web site that provides useful holiday ideas for almost all the cities in India. Find out all the details on various cities and tourist attractions such as bird sanctuaries, wild life preservations, etc., at IndiaE-Travel (www.indiaetravel.com).

Another interesting Web site is Travel Jini (www.traveljini.com). Apart from providing some very interesting holiday ideas, it also has a special honeymoon section for romantic getaways.

Visit the hyperlinks page at Tourism of India (<http://www.tourismofindia.com/foot/links.htm>) for detailed information about a particular state in India. Here, you

can find links to the official sites of state tourism departments. To assist you in finalising your holiday destination, there's Maps of India (www.mapsofindia.com), which has maps of all the states, their major cities and the connecting roads and highways.

Tickets, please

Cryptic station names and train codes notwithstanding, the functionality of the Indian Railways Web site (www.indianrail.gov.in) has improved immensely after its re-launch in May last year. The Web site not only gives you extensive information of train routes and timings, but also lets you check the availability of seats.



The Maps of India site gives you decently detailed maps of just about any holiday destination you choose

To book your train tickets online, you need to log on to the Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation (IRCTC) Web site at www.irctc.co.in.

If you want to travel by air, it makes sense to plan ahead and avail yourself of APEX fares. Alternatively, you can also try the bidding options available at the Web sites of domestic airlines.

If you're really lucky, you can save as much as 50 to 60 per cent of the air fare. Log on to <http://indianairlines.indiatimes.com> to bid for Indian Airlines tickets. You can place a bid seven days in advance, but the bid will last for five days and is only available for selected routes. You can also buy the tickets directly from the official Indian Airlines Web site (<http://indianairlines.nic.in>), but there are a few limitations—you can't book tickets within 96 hours of departure and can't book tickets on discounted fares.

Air Sahara also allows you to bid for tickets up to 15 days in advance. Visit <http://airsahara.indiatimes.com>, or www.airsahara.net.

Travel Jini also has a very useful feature called Flight Route Finder. Key in the origin and destination airport in India and it shows you all the possible routes. The site also gives you the route with the cheapest fares between the selected destinations.

Want to book a hotel?

"We have always stayed at the hotels of our choice, without paying a premium," claims Rupesh Shah, a south Mumbai businessman and a savvy traveller, who is as meticulous as ever when he plans his family vacation. Earlier, he would dig into travel brochures or guidebooks for advance hotel bookings. Now, he scours



Find some interesting holiday ideas, exhaustive list of tour operators and more information at the official website of Ministry of Tourism at www.tourismofindia.com